



(12) **United States Patent**
Xue et al.

(10) **Patent No.:** **US 12,408,557 B2**
(45) **Date of Patent:** **Sep. 2, 2025**

(54) **METHODS FOR FORMING STRUCTURES WITH DESIRED CRYSTALLINITY FOR MRAM APPLICATIONS**

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(*) Notice: Subject to any disclaimer, the term of this patent is extended or adjusted under 35 U.S.C. 154(b) by 0 days.

(21) Appl. No.: **17/486,649**

(22) Filed: **Sep. 27, 2021**

(65) **Prior Publication Data**

US 2022/0013716 A1 Jan. 13, 2022

Related U.S. Application Data

(62) Division of application No. 15/438,420, filed on Feb. 21, 2017, now Pat. No. 11,133,460, which is a (Continued)

(51) **Int. Cl.**
H10N 50/01 (2023.01)
H01F 10/14 (2006.01)
(Continued)

(52) **U.S. Cl.**
CPC **H10N 50/01** (2023.02); **H01F 10/14** (2013.01); **H01F 10/3222** (2013.01); **H10N 50/10** (2023.02); **H10N 50/85** (2023.02)

(58) **Field of Classification Search**
CPC H10N 50/85; H10N 50/01; H01F 10/14; H01F 10/3222

See application file for complete search history.

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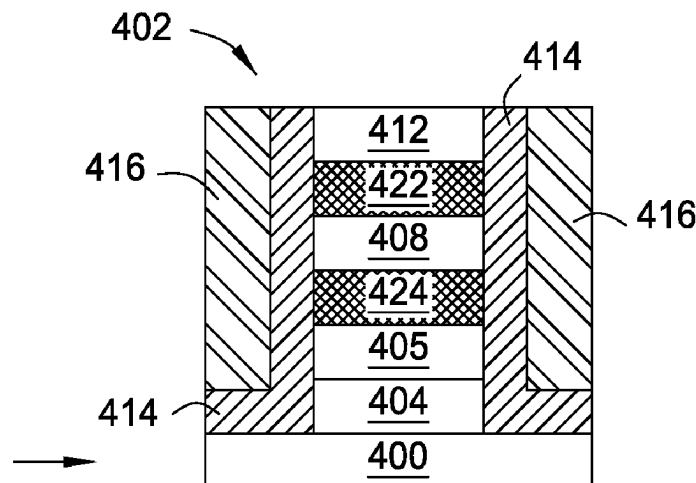
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(57) **ABSTRACT**

Embodiments of the disclosure provide methods and apparatus for fabricating magnetic tunnel junction (MTJ) structures on a substrate in for spin-transfer-torque magnetoresistive random access memory (STT-MRAM) applications. In one example, a film stack utilized to form a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate includes a pinned layer disposed on a substrate, wherein the pinned layer comprises multiple layers including at least one or more of a Co containing layer, Pt containing layer, Ta containing layer, an Ru containing layer, an optional structure decoupling layer disposed on the pinned magnetic layer, a magnetic reference layer disposed on the optional structure decoupling layer, a tunneling barrier layer disposed on the magnetic reference layer, a magnetic storage layer disposed on the tunneling barrier layer, and a capping layer disposed on the magnetic storage layer.

20 Claims, 5 Drawing Sheets



Related U.S. Application Data

division of application No. 15/199,006, filed on Jun. 30, 2016, now Pat. No. 11,245,069.

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(60) Provisional application No. 62/192,565, filed on Jul. 14, 2015.

(51) Int. Cl.

H01F 10/32 (2006.01)

H10N 50/10 (2023.01)

H10N 50/85 (2023.01)

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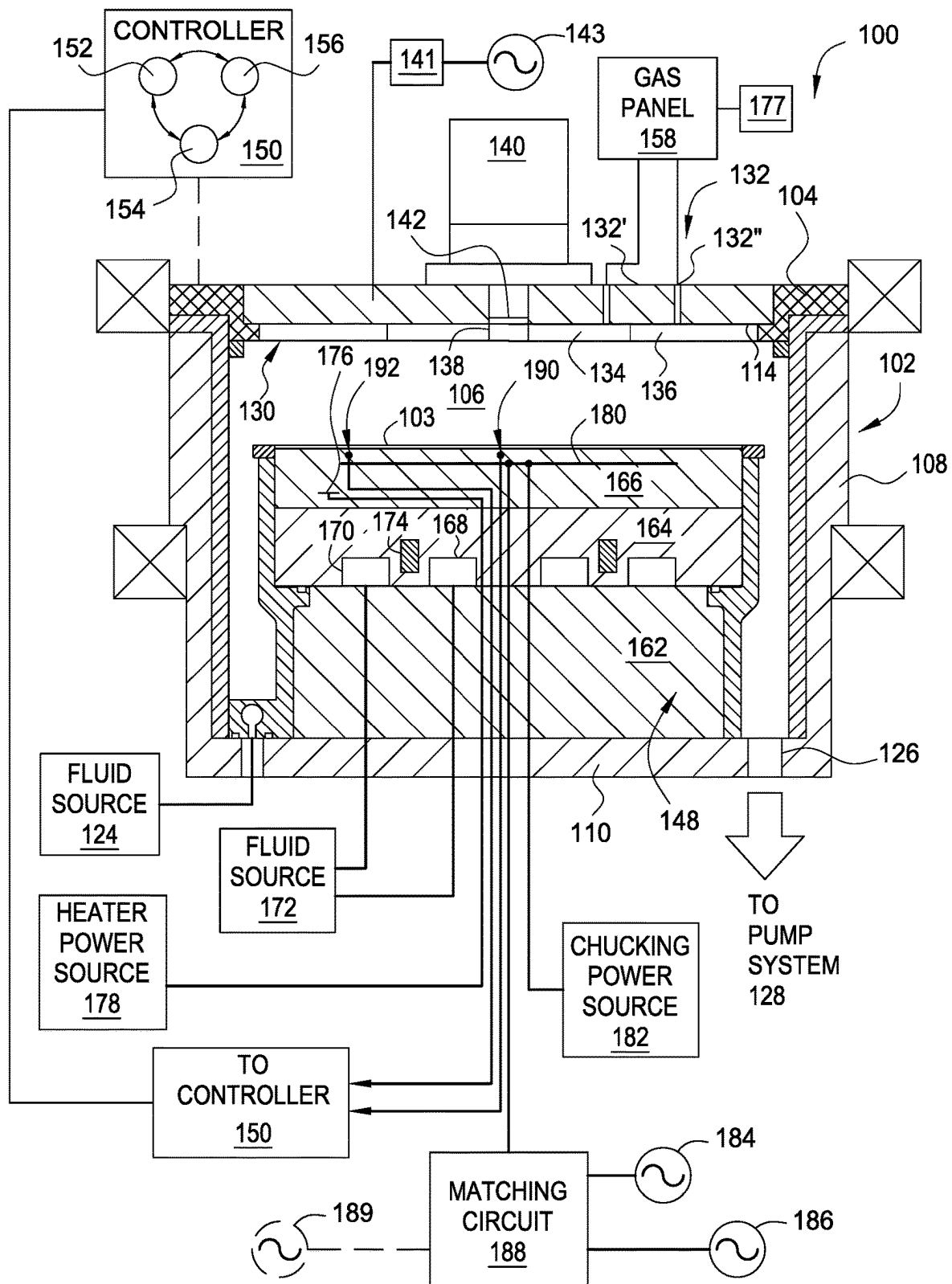


FIG. 1

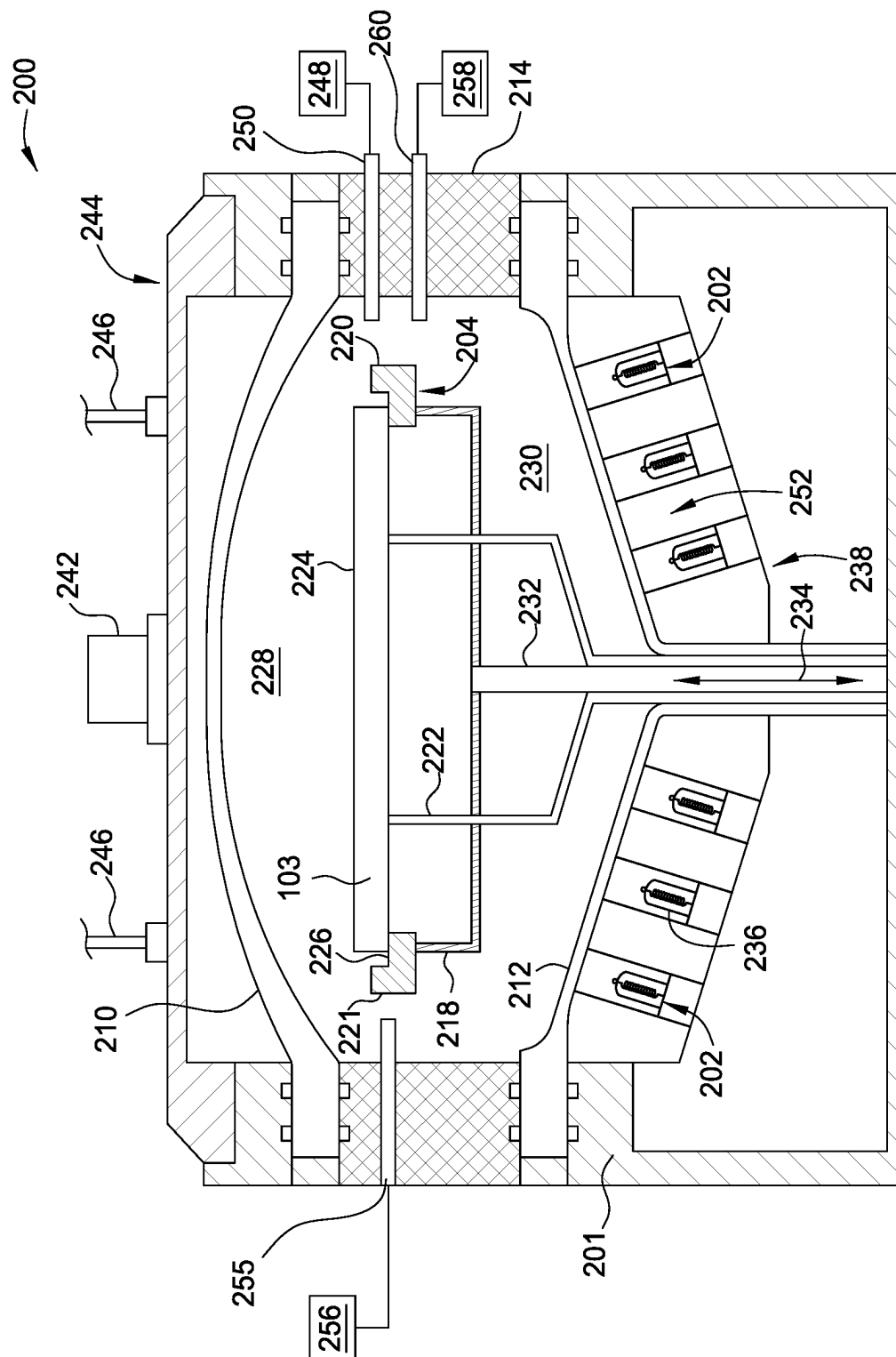


FIG. 2

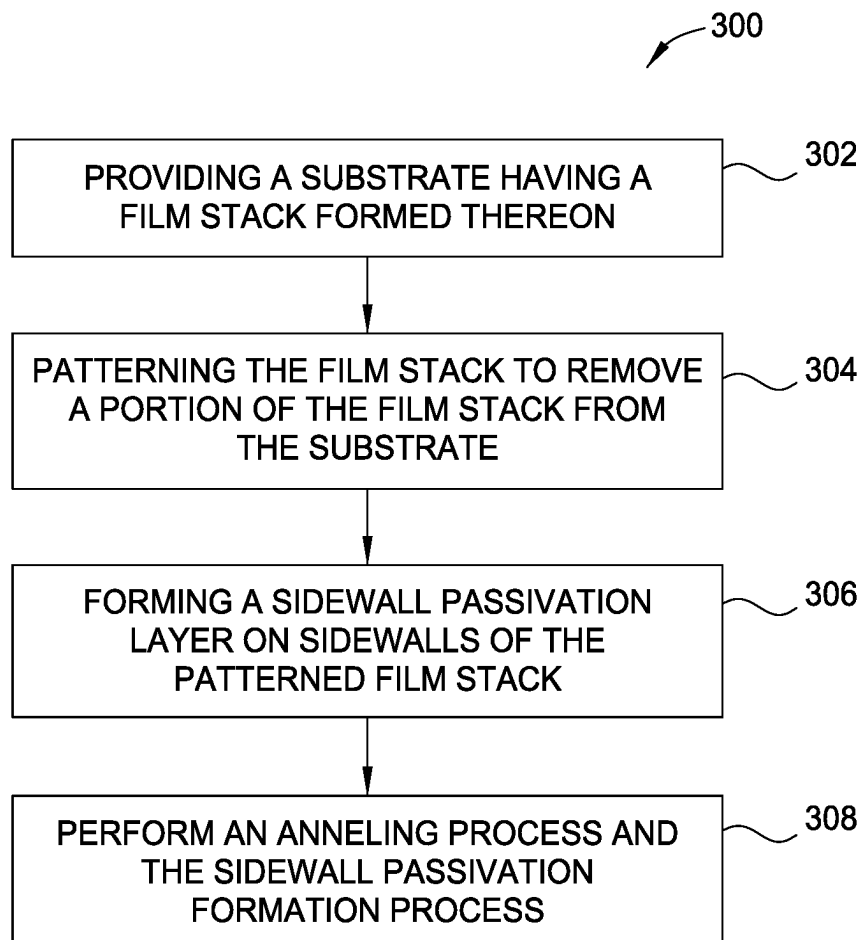


FIG. 3

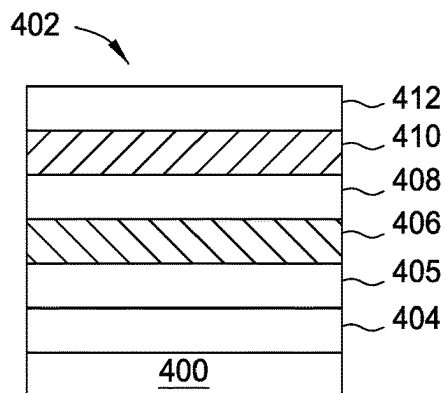


FIG. 4A

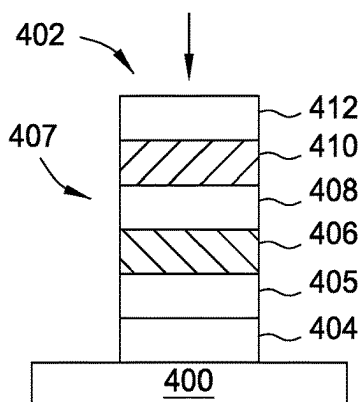


FIG. 4B

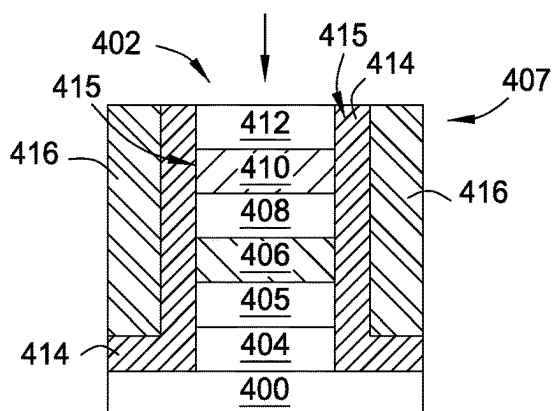


FIG. 4C

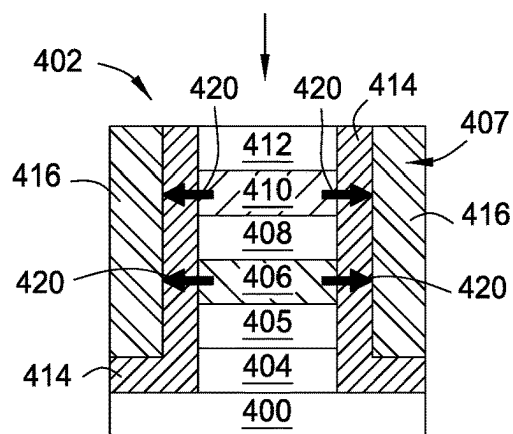


FIG. 4D

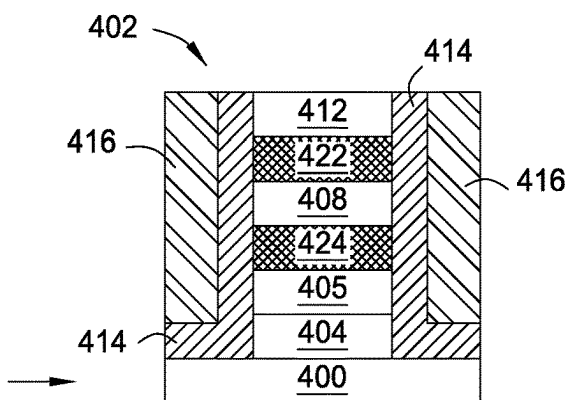


FIG. 4E

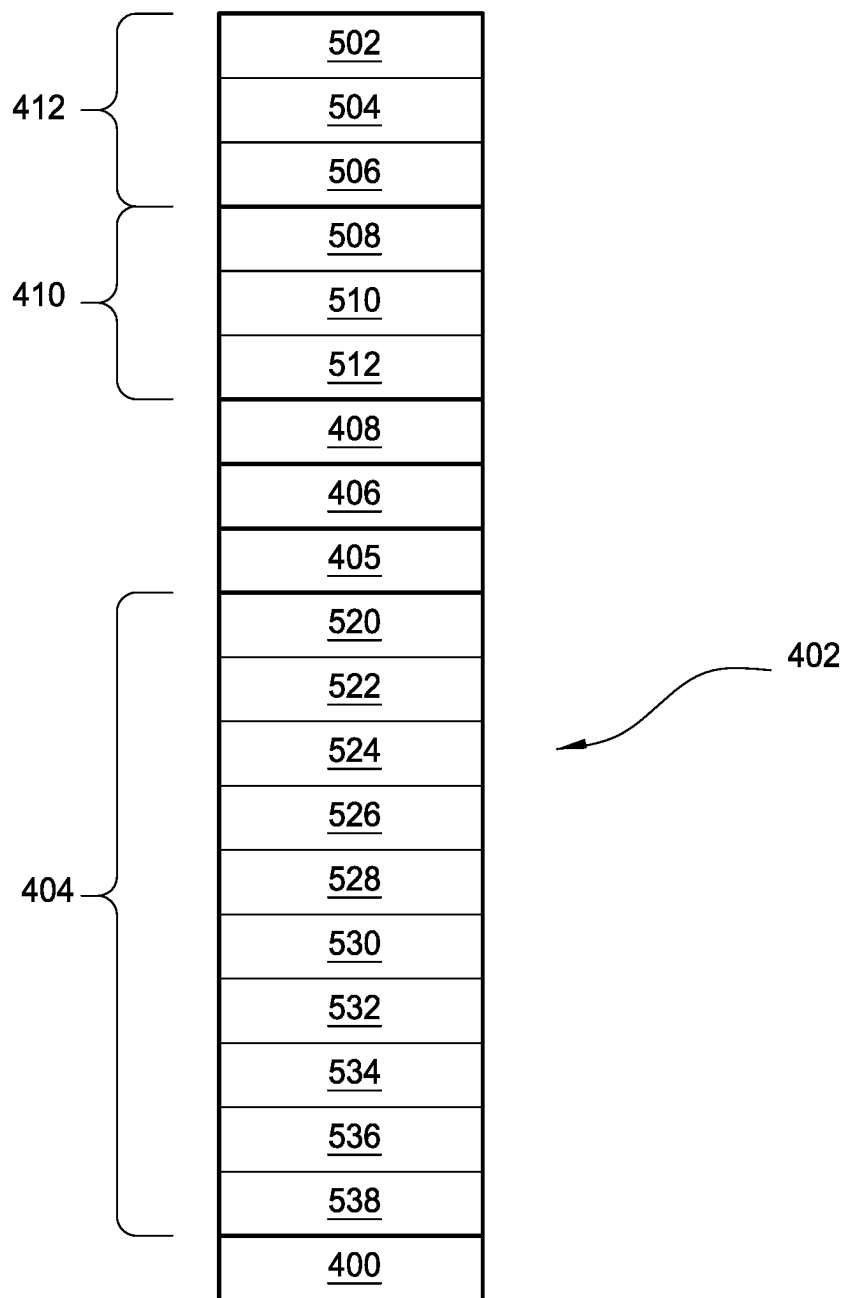


FIG. 5

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METHODS FOR FORMING STRUCTURES WITH DESIRED CRYSTALLINITY FOR MRAM APPLICATIONS

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

This application is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/438,420, filed Feb. 21, 2017, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/199,006, filed Jun. 30, 2016, which claims benefit of U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 62/192,565 filed Jul. 14, 2015, which is incorporated by reference in its entirety.

FIELD

Embodiments of the disclosure relate to methods for fabricating structures used in magnetoresistive random access memory (MRAM) applications. More specifically, embodiments of the disclosure relate to methods for fabricating magnetic tunnel junction structures for MRAM applications.

BACKGROUND

Magnetoresistive random access memory (MRAM) is a type of memory device containing an array of MRAM cells that store data using their resistance values instead of electronic charges. Generally, each MRAM cell includes a magnetic tunnel junction (MTJ) structure. The MTJ structure may have adjustable resistance to represent a logic state “0” or “1.” The MTJ structure typically includes a stack of magnetic layers having a configuration in which two ferromagnetic layers are separated by a thin non-magnetic dielectric, e.g., an insulating tunneling layer. A top electrode and a bottom electrode are utilized to sandwich the MTJ structure so electric current may flow between the top and the bottom electrode.

One ferromagnetic layer, e.g., a reference layer, is characterized by a magnetization with a fixed direction. The other ferromagnetic layer, e.g., a storage layer, is characterized by a magnetization with a direction that is varied upon writing of the device, such as by applying a magnetic field. In some devices, an insulator material, such as a dielectric oxide layer, may be formed as a thin tunneling barrier layer sandwiched between the ferromagnetic layers. The layers are typically deposited sequentially as overlying blanketed films. The ferromagnetic layers and the insulator material are subsequently patterned by various etching processes in which one or more layers are removed, either partially or totally, in order to form a device feature.

When the respective magnetizations of the reference layer and the storage layer are antiparallel, a resistance of the magnetic tunnel junction is high having a resistance value R_{max} corresponding to a high logic state “1”. On the other hand, when the respective magnetizations are parallel, the resistance of the magnetic tunnel junction is low, namely having a resistance value R_{min} corresponding to a low logic state “0”. A logic state of a MRAM cell is read by comparing its resistance value to a reference resistance value R_{ref} which is derived from a reference cell or a group of reference cells and represents an in-between resistance value between that of the high logic state “1” and the low logic state “0”.

One type of MRAM cell is spin-transfer-torque magnetic random access memory (STT-MRAM). While manufacturing conventional STT-MRAM devices, a thermal annealing

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process is often performed right after the film layer deposition process to assist crystallization of the ferromagnetic layers as well as the insulator material sandwiched in the device structure. Insufficient thermal energy or inaccurate temperature control during the annealing process may cause the film bonding structures or properties formed in an undesirable manner. For example, inaccurate temperature control or undesired drift of the thermal diffusion during the annealing process may result in insufficient crystallization of the film layer, leading to failure of the device to meet its intended performance.

Therefore, there is a need in the art for improved methods and apparatus for fabricating MTJ structures for MRAM applications.

SUMMARY

Embodiments of the disclosure provide methods and apparatus for fabricating magnetic tunnel junction (MTJ) structures on a substrate in MRAM applications, particularly for spin-transfer-torque magnetic random access memory (STT-MRAM) applications. In one embodiment, a film stack utilized to form a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate includes a pinned layer disposed on a substrate, wherein the pinned layer comprises multiple layers including at least one or more of a Co containing layer, a Pt containing layer, a Ta containing layer, an Ru containing layer and combinations thereof, an optional structure decoupling layer disposed on the pinned magnetic layer, a magnetic reference layer disposed on the optional structure decoupling layer, a tunneling barrier layer disposed on the magnetic reference layer, a magnetic storage layer disposed on the tunneling barrier layer, and a capping layer disposed on the magnetic storage layer.

In another embodiment, the method includes patterning a film stack having a tunneling barrier layer disposed between a magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer disposed on a substrate to remove a portion of the film stack from the substrate until an upper surface of the substrate is exposed, forming a sidewall passivation layer on sidewalls of the patterned film stack and subsequently performing a thermal annealing process to the film stack.

In yet another embodiment, a method of forming a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate includes patterning a film stack having a tunneling barrier layer disposed between a magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer disposed on a substrate to remove a portion of the film stack from the substrate until an upper surface of the substrate is exposed, forming a sidewall passivation layer on sidewalls of the patterned film stack, forming an insulation layer in contact with the sidewall passivation layer on the substrate, and driving dopants from the magnetic reference layer and the magnetic storage layer laterally outward into the sidewall passivation layer by a thermal treatment process.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

So that the manner in which the above-recited features of the present disclosure can be understood in detail, a more particular description of the disclosure, briefly summarized above, may be had by reference to embodiments, some of which are illustrated in the appended drawings.

FIG. 1 depicts one embodiment of a plasma processing chamber for practice one embodiment of the present disclosure;

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FIG. 2 depicts one embodiment of an annealing chamber for practice one embodiment of the present disclosure;

FIG. 3 depicts a flow diagram illustrating a method for fabricating magnetic tunnel junction (MTJ) structures according to one embodiment of the present disclosure;

FIGS. 4A-4E are schematic side views of a substrate at various stages of the method of FIG. 3; and

FIG. 5 is a schematic diagram of another embodiment of a portion of the film stack illustrated in FIG. 4A.

To facilitate understanding, identical reference numerals have been used, where possible, to designate identical elements that are common to the figures. It is contemplated that elements disclosed in one embodiment may be beneficially utilized on other embodiments without specific recitation.

It is to be noted, however, that the appended drawings illustrate only typical embodiments of this disclosure and are therefore not to be considered limiting of its scope, for the disclosure may admit to other equally effective embodiments.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

Embodiments of the disclosure generally provide apparatus and methods for forming MTJ structures from a film stack disposed on a substrate for MRAM applications. The apparatus and methods include forming the film properties of material layers from the film stack with desired crystallinity by a thermal process performed after the patterning of the material layers in the film stack. While patterning, a sidewall passivation layer may be formed along sidewalls of the film stack. Thus, by performing the thermal process after the patterning process and the sidewall passivation deposition process, the thermal energy provided from the thermal process may efficiently diffuse dopants into the material layers laterally outward toward the sidewall passivation layer, rather than vertically to adjacent material layers formed in the film stack. By doing so, a controllable degree of crystallinity of the material layers in the film stack may be obtained without damage or interference from the dopants that might potentially be cross-diffused from the adjacent materials. The film stack as patterned and annealed with desired degree of crystallinity may be used to form MTJ structures with desired dimension and features for MRAM applications.

FIG. 1 is a sectional view of one example of a processing chamber 100 suitable for performing a patterning process to etch a film stack disposed on a substrate. Suitable processing chambers that may be adapted for use with the teachings disclosed herein include, for example, an ENABLER®, C3® or AdvantEdge Mesa® processing chamber available from Applied Materials, Inc. of Santa Clara, California. Although the processing chamber 100 is shown including a plurality of features that enable superior etching performance, it is contemplated that other processing chambers may be adapted to benefit from one or more of the inventive features disclosed herein.

The processing chamber 100 includes a chamber body 102 and a lid 104 which enclose an interior volume 106. The chamber body 102 is typically fabricated from aluminum, stainless steel or other suitable material. The chamber body 102 generally includes sidewalls 108 and a bottom 110. A substrate support pedestal access port (not shown) is generally defined in a sidewall 108 and a selectively sealed by a slit valve to facilitate entry and egress of a substrate 103 from the processing chamber 100. An exhaust port 126 is defined in the chamber body 102 and couples the interior

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volume 106 to a pump system 128. The pump system 128 generally includes one or more pumps and throttle valves utilized to evacuate and regulate the pressure of the interior volume 106 of the processing chamber 100. In one implementation, the pump system 128 maintains the pressure inside the interior volume 106 at operating pressures typically between about 10 mTorr to about 500 Torr.

The lid 104 is sealingly supported on the sidewall 108 of the chamber body 102. The lid 104 may be opened to allow excess to the interior volume 106 of the processing chamber 100. The lid 104 includes a window 142 that facilitates optical process monitoring. In one implementation, the window 142 is comprised of quartz or other suitable material that is transmissive to a signal utilized by an optical monitoring system 140 mounted outside the processing chamber 100.

The optical monitoring system 140 is positioned to view at least one of the interior volume 106 of the chamber body 102 and/or the substrate 103 positioned on a substrate support pedestal assembly 148 through the window 142. In one embodiment, the optical monitoring system 140 is coupled to the lid 104 and facilitates an integrated deposition process that uses optical metrology to provide information that enables process adjustment to compensate for incoming substrate pattern feature inconsistencies (such as thickness, and the like), provide process state monitoring (such as plasma monitoring, temperature monitoring, and the like) as needed. One optical monitoring system that may be adapted to benefit from the disclosure is the EyeD® full-spectrum, interferometric metrology module, available from Applied Materials, Inc., of Santa Clara, California.

A gas panel 158 is coupled to the processing chamber 100 to provide process and/or cleaning gases to the interior volume 106. In the example depicted in FIG. 1, inlet ports 132', 132" are provided in the lid 104 to allow gases to be delivered from the gas panel 158 to the interior volume 106 of the processing chamber 100. In one implementation, the gas panel 158 is adapted to provide fluorinated process gas through the inlet ports 132', 132" and into the interior volume 106 of the processing chamber 100. In one implementation, the process gas provided from the gas panel 158 includes at least a fluorinated gas, chlorine, and a carbon containing gas, an oxygen gas, a nitrogen containing gas and a chlorine containing gas. Examples of fluorinated and carbon containing gases include CHF₃, CH₂F₂ and CF₄. Other fluorinated gases may include one or more of C₂F₆, C₃F₈ and C₅F₈. Examples of the oxygen containing gas include O₂, CO₂, CO, N₂O, NO₂, O₃, H₂O, and the like. Examples of the nitrogen containing gas include N₂, NH₃, N₂O, NO₂ and the like. Examples of the chlorine containing gas include HCl, Cl₂, CCl₄, CHCl₃, CH₂Cl₂, CH₃Cl, and the like. Suitable examples of the carbon containing gas include methane (CH₄), ethane (C₂H₆), ethylene (C₂H₄), and the like.

A showerhead assembly 130 is coupled to an interior surface 114 of the lid 104. The showerhead assembly 130 includes a plurality of apertures that allow the gases flowing through the showerhead assembly 130 from the inlet ports 132', 132" into the interior volume 106 of the processing chamber 100 in a predefined distribution across the surface of the substrate 103 being processed in the processing chamber 100.

A remote plasma source 177 may be optionally coupled to the gas panel 158 to facilitate dissociating gas mixture from a remote plasma prior to entering into the interior volume 106 for processing. A RF source power 143 is coupled through a matching network 141 to the showerhead assembly

bly **130**. The RF source power **143** typically is capable of producing up to about 3000 W at a tunable frequency in a range from about 50 kHz to about 200 MHz.

The showerhead assembly **130** additionally includes a region transmissive to an optical metrology signal. The optically transmissive region or passage **138** is suitable for allowing the optical monitoring system **140** to view the interior volume **106** and/or the substrate **103** positioned on the substrate support pedestal assembly **148**. The passage **138** may be a material, an aperture or plurality of apertures formed or disposed in the showerhead assembly **130** that is substantially transmissive to the wavelengths of energy generated by, and reflected back to, the optical monitoring system **140**. In one embodiment, the passage **138** includes a window **142** to prevent gas leakage through the passage **138**. The window **142** may be a sapphire plate, quartz plate or other suitable material. The window **142** may alternatively be disposed in the lid **104**.

In one implementation, the showerhead assembly **130** is configured with a plurality of zones that allow for separate control of gas flowing into the interior volume **106** of the processing chamber **100**. In the example illustrated in FIG. 1, the showerhead assembly **130** as an inner zone **134** and an outer zone **136** that are separately coupled to the gas panel **158** through separate inlet ports **132'**, **132''**.

The substrate support pedestal assembly **148** is disposed in the interior volume **106** of the processing chamber **100** below the gas distribution (showerhead) assembly **130**. The substrate support pedestal assembly **148** holds the substrate **103** during processing. The substrate support pedestal assembly **148** generally includes a plurality of lift pins (not shown) disposed therethrough that are configured to lift the substrate **103** from the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** and facilitate exchange of the substrate **103** with a robot (not shown) in a conventional manner. An inner liner **118** may closely circumscribe the periphery of the substrate support pedestal assembly **148**.

In one implementation, the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** includes a mounting plate **162**, a base **164** and an electrostatic chuck **166**. The mounting plate **162** is coupled to the bottom **110** of the chamber body **102** includes passages for routing utilities, such as fluids, power lines and sensor leads, among others, to the base **164** and the electrostatic chuck **166**. The electrostatic chuck **166** comprises at least one clamping electrode **180** for retaining the substrate **103** below showerhead assembly **130**. The electrostatic chuck **166** is driven by a chucking power source **182** to develop an electrostatic force that holds the substrate **103** to the chuck surface, as is conventionally known. Alternatively, the substrate **103** may be retained to the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** by clamping, vacuum or gravity.

At least one of the base **164** or electrostatic chuck **166** may include at least one optional embedded heater **176**, at least one optional embedded isolator **174** and a plurality of conduits **168**, **170** to control the lateral temperature profile of the substrate support pedestal assembly **148**. The conduits **168**, **170** are fluidly coupled to a fluid source **172** that circulates a temperature regulating fluid therethrough. The heater **176** is regulated by a power source **178**. The conduits **168**, **170** and heater **176** are utilized to control the temperature of the base **164**, thereby heating and/or cooling the electrostatic chuck **166** and ultimately, the temperature profile of the substrate **103** disposed thereon. The temperature of the electrostatic chuck **166** and the base **164** may be monitored using a plurality of temperature sensors **190**, **192**. The electrostatic chuck **166** may further comprise a plurality of gas passages (not shown), such as grooves, that are

formed in a substrate support pedestal supporting surface of the chuck **166** and fluidly coupled to a source of a heat transfer (or backside) gas, such as He. In operation, the backside gas is provided at controlled pressure into the gas passages to enhance the heat transfer between the electrostatic chuck **166** and the substrate **103**.

In one implementation, the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** is configured as a cathode and includes an electrode **180** that is coupled to a plurality of RF power bias sources **184**, **186**. The RF bias power sources **184**, **186** are coupled between the electrode **180** disposed in the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** and another electrode, such as the showerhead assembly **130** or ceiling (lid **104**) of the chamber body **102**. The RF bias power excites and sustains a plasma discharge formed from the gases disposed in the processing region of the chamber body **102**.

In the example depicted in FIG. 1, the dual RF bias power sources **184**, **186** are coupled to the electrode **180** disposed in the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** through a matching circuit **188**. The signal generated by the RF bias power sources **184**, **186** is delivered through matching circuit **188** to the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** through a single feed to ionize the gas mixture provided in the plasma processing chamber **100**, thereby providing ion energy necessary for performing a deposition or other plasma enhanced process. The RF bias power sources **184**, **186** are generally capable of producing an RF signal having a frequency of from about 50 kHz to about 200 MHz and a power between about 0 Watts and about 5000 Watts. An additional bias power source **189** may be coupled to the electrode **180** to control the characteristics of the plasma.

In one mode of operation, the substrate **103** is disposed on the substrate support pedestal assembly **148** in the plasma processing chamber **100**. A process gas and/or gas mixture is introduced into the chamber body **102** through the showerhead assembly **130** from the gas panel **158**. A vacuum pump system **128** maintains the pressure inside the chamber body **102** while removing deposition by-products.

A controller **150** is coupled to the processing chamber **100** to control operation of the processing chamber **100**. The controller **150** includes a central processing unit (CPU) **152**, a memory **154**, and a support circuit **156** utilized to control the process sequence and regulate the gas flows from the gas panel **158**. The CPU **152** may be any form of general purpose computer processor that may be used in an industrial setting. The software routines can be stored in the memory **154**, such as random access memory, read only memory, floppy, or hard disk drive, or other form of digital storage. The support circuit **156** is conventionally coupled to the CPU **152** and may include cache, clock circuits, input/output systems, power supplies, and the like. Bi-directional communications between the controller **150** and the various components of the processing chamber **100** are handled through numerous signal cables.

FIG. 2 illustrates a schematic view of a processing chamber **200** according to one embodiment. The processing chamber **200** may be used to process the substrate **103**, including providing thermal/heat energy to material layers disposed on the substrate **103**. The processing chamber **200** may include an array of radiant heating lamps **202** for heating, among other components, a back side **204** of a susceptor **220** disposed within walls **201** of the processing chamber **200**, and the substrate **103**. The susceptor **220** is supported by a susceptor support **218**. In the embodiment shown in FIG. 2, the susceptor **220** has a ring shaped body with a central opening **203** and a lip **221** that extends from the edge of the susceptor **220** and circumscribes the central

opening 203. The lip 221 and the front side 202 of the susceptor 220 create a pocket 226 that supports the substrate 103 from the edge of the substrate to facilitate exposure of the substrate 103 to the thermal radiation provided by the lamps 202.

The susceptor 220 is located within the processing chamber 200 between an upper dome 210 and a lower dome 212. The upper dome 210 is coupled to the lower dome 212 by a base ring 214. The upper dome 210, the lower dome 212 and the base ring 214 generally define an internal region of the processing chamber 200. In some embodiments, the array of radiant heating lamps 202 may be disposed over the upper dome 210. The substrate 301 can be brought into the processing chamber 200 and positioned onto the susceptor 220 through a loading port (not shown) formed in the base ring 214.

The susceptor 220 is shown in an elevated processing position, but may be moved vertically by an actuator (not shown) to a loading position below the processing position to allow lift pins 222 to pass through holes in the susceptor support 218, and raise the substrate 103 from the susceptor 220. A robot (not shown) may then enter the processing chamber 200 to engage and remove the substrate 103 therefrom through the loading port. The susceptor 220 then may be actuated up to the processing position to place the substrate 103, with a device side 224 facing up, on a front side 202 of the susceptor 220.

The susceptor 220 and the susceptor support 218, while located in the processing position, divide the internal volume of the processing chamber 200 into a process gas region 228 that is above the substrate 103, and a purge gas region 230 below the susceptor 220 and the susceptor support 218. The susceptor 220 and susceptor support 218 are rotated during processing by a supporting cylindrical central shaft 232, to minimize the effect of thermal and process gas flow spatial anomalies within the processing chamber 200, and thus facilitate uniform processing of the substrate 103. The central shaft 232 moves the substrate 301 in an up and down direction 234 during loading and unloading, and in some instances, during processing of the substrate 103.

In general, the central window portion of the upper dome 210 and the bottom of the lower dome 212 are formed from an optically transparent material, such as quartz. One or more lamps, such as an array of the lamps 202, can be disposed adjacent to and beneath the lower dome 212 in a specified, optimal desired manner around the central shaft 232 to independently control the temperature at various regions of the substrate 103. The heated substrate 103 is exposed to the process gases, thereby facilitating the thermal processing (i.e., deposition) of a material onto the upper surface of the substrate 103.

The lamps 202 may be configured to include bulbs 236 and may be configured to heat the substrate 301 to a temperature within a range of about 200 degrees Celsius to about 1600 degrees Celsius, for example, between about 300 degrees Celsius to about 1200 degrees Celsius or between about 500 to about 580 degrees Celsius. Each lamp 202 is coupled to a power distribution board (not shown) through which power is supplied to each lamp 202. The lamps 202 are positioned within a lamphead 238 which may be cooled during or after processing by, for example, a cooling fluid introduced into channels 252 located between the lamps 202. The lamphead 238 conductively and radiantly cools the lower dome 212 due in part to the close proximity of the lamphead 238 to the lower dome 212. The lamphead 238 may also cool the lamp walls and walls of the reflectors (not shown) around the lamps. Alternatively, the lower dome 212

may be cooled by a convective approach known, such as by fans or other cooling techniques. Depending upon the application, the lampheads 238 may or may not be in contact with the lower dome 212. As a result of backside heating of the substrate 103, the use of an optical pyrometer 242 for temperature measurements/control on the substrate 103 and the susceptor 220 may also be utilized.

A reflector 244 may be optionally placed outside the upper dome 210 to reflect infrared light that is radiating off the substrate 301 back onto the substrate 301. The reflector 244 may be fabricated from a metal such as aluminum or stainless steel. The efficiency of the reflection can be improved by coating a reflector area with a highly reflective coating, such as with gold. The reflector 244 can have one or more machined channels 246 connected to a cooling source (not shown). The channel 246 connects to a passage (not shown) formed on a side of the reflector 244. The passage is configured to carry a flow of a fluid such as water and may run horizontally along the side of the reflector 244 in any desired pattern covering a portion or entire surface of the reflector 244 for cooling the reflector 244.

Process gas supplied from a process gas supply source 248 is introduced into the process gas region 228 through a process gas inlet 250 formed in the sidewall of the base ring 214. The process gas inlet 250 is configured to direct the process gas in a generally radially inward direction. During the film formation process, the susceptor 220 may be located in the processing position, which is adjacent to and at about the same elevation as the process gas inlet 250, allowing the process gas to flow up and round along a flow path across the upper surface of the substrate 103 in a laminar flow. The process gas exits the process gas region 228 through a gas outlet 255 located on the side of the processing chamber 200 opposite the process gas inlet 250. Removal of the process gas through the gas outlet 255 may be facilitated by a vacuum pump 256 coupled thereto. As the process gas inlet 250 and the gas outlet 255 are aligned and disposed approximately at the same elevation, it is believed that such a parallel arrangement, when combined with a flatter upper dome 210 provides generally planar, uniform gas flow across the substrate 103. Further radial uniformity may be provided by the rotation of the substrate 103 by the susceptor 220.

Purge gas may be supplied from a purge gas source 258 to the purge gas region 230 through an optional purge gas inlet 260 (or through the process gas inlet 250) formed in the sidewall of the base ring 214. The purge gas inlet 260 is disposed at an elevation below the process gas inlet 250. The purge gas inlet 260 is configured to direct the purge gas in a generally radially inward direction. During the process, the susceptor 220 may be located at a position such that the purge gas flows down and along a flow path across the back side 204 of the susceptor 220 in a laminar flow. Without being bound by any particular theory, the flowing of the purge gas is believed to prevent or substantially avoid the flow of the process gas from entering into the purge gas region 230, or to reduce diffusion of the process gas entering the purge gas region 230 (i.e., the region under the susceptor 220). The purge gas exits the purge gas region 230 and is exhausted out of the processing chamber 200 through the gas outlet 255, which is located on the side of the processing chamber 200 opposite the purge gas inlet 260.

FIG. 3 depicts a flow diagram illustrating a process 300 for manufacturing MTJ structures on a substrate for MRAM applications according to one embodiment of the present disclosure. FIGS. 4A-4E are schematic cross-sectional views of a substrate 400 at various stages of the process of

FIG. 3. The process 300 is configured to be performed in a plasma processing chamber and a thermal processing chamber, such as the processing chambers 100, 200 as described in FIGS. 1 and 2. It is contemplated that the process 300 may be performed in other suitable plasma immersion ion implantation systems or etching chamber, including those from other manufacturers.

The process 300 begins at operation 302 by providing a substrate, such as the substrate 400 having a film stack 402 disposed thereon. FIG. 5 is a schematic diagram of one embodiment of a portion of the film stack 402 illustrated in FIG. 4A. In one embodiment, the substrate 400 comprises metal or glass, silicon, dielectric bulk material and metal alloys or composite glass, crystalline silicon (e.g., Si<100> or Si<111>), silicon oxide, strained silicon, silicon germanium, germanium, doped or undoped polysilicon, doped or undoped silicon wafers and patterned or non-patterned wafers silicon on insulator (SOI), carbon doped silicon oxides, silicon nitride, doped silicon, germanium, gallium arsenide, glass, or sapphire. The substrate 400 may have various dimensions, such as 200 mm, 300 mm, 450 mm or other diameter, as well as, being a rectangular or square panel. Unless otherwise noted, examples described herein are conducted on substrates with a 200 mm diameter, a 300 mm diameter, or a 450 mm diameter substrate. In one embodiment, the substrate 400, as shown in FIG. 4A, includes the film stack 402 disposed on the substrate 400.

In one example, the film stack 402 includes a pinned magnetic layer 404, an optional structure decoupling layer 405 and a tunneling barrier layer 408, which may be an oxide barrier layer in the case of a tunnel junction magnetoresistive (TMR) sensor or a conductive layer in the case of a giant magnetoresistive (GMR) sensor, disposed above the pinned magnetic layer 404 sandwiched between a magnetic storage layer 410 and a magnetic reference layer 406. When the film stack 402 is configured to form a TMR sensor, then the tunneling barrier layer 408 may comprise MgO, HfO₂, TiO₂, TaO_x, Al₂O₃, or other suitable materials. In the embodiment depicted in FIG. 5, the tunneling barrier layer 408 may comprise MgO having a thickness of about 1 to about 15 Angstroms, such about 10 Angstroms. The tunneling barrier layer 408 may be annealed either during or post deposition, for example, using a rapid thermal anneal (RTP) process.

If the film stack 402 is configured to form a GMR sensor, film stack 402 may comprise a non-magnetic conductive material, such as copper. The structure decoupling layer 405 may be a metal containing material or a magnetic material, such as Mo, Ta, W, CoFe, CoFeB and the like.

In one example, the pinned magnetic layer 404 may have a thickness of about 2 nm. The pinned magnetic layer 404 may comprise one of several types of pinned layers, such as a simple pinned, antiparallel pinned, self pinned or antiferromagnetic pinned sensor. The pinned magnetic layer 404, the magnetic storage layer 410 and the magnetic reference layer 406 may be constructed of several magnetic materials such as a metal alloy with dopants, such as boron dopants, oxygen dopants or other suitable materials. Metal alloys may be a nickel containing material, platinum containing material, Ru containing material, a cobalt containing material, tantalum containing materials and palladium containing materials. Suitable examples of the magnetic materials that may comprise the pinned magnetic layer 404 include Ru, Ta, Co, Pt, TaN, NiFeO_x, NiFeB, CoFeO_xB, CoFeB, CoFe, NiO_xB, CoBO_x, FeBO_x, CoFeNiB, CoPt, CoPd, TaO_x and the like.

In the embodiment depicted in FIG. 4A, the magnetic storage layer 410 may be a CoFeB, CoFeNiB, Ta, Mo or W, combinations thereof or other suitable layer(s). For example, in the embodiment depicted in FIG. 5, the magnetic storage layer 410 includes a first CoFeB layer 508 and a second CoFeB layer 512 sandwiching an intermediate layer 510. The first and second CoFeB layers 508, 512 may have a thickness of about 5 to about 20 Angstroms, for example about 10 Angstroms, a composition of B in the range of about 10 to about 30 percent, and a composition of Fe in the range of about 20 to about 60 percent. The intermediate layer 510 may include one or more layers of at least one or more of Ta, Mo and W. The intermediate layer 510 may have a thickness of about 0 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 3 Angstroms.

The magnetic reference layer 406 may be CoFeB or other suitable layer. The magnetic reference layer 406 may have a thickness of about 5 to about 20 Angstroms, for example about 10 Angstroms. The magnetic reference layer 406 may have a composition of about 10 to about 30 percent of boron (B), and about 20 to about 60 percent Fe.

The structure decoupling layer 405 is disposed between the magnetic reference layer 406 and the pinned magnetic layer 404. The structure decoupling layer 405 may include one or more layers of at least one or more of Ta, Mo and W. The structure decoupling layer 405 may have a thickness of about 0 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 3 Angstroms.

The pinned magnetic layer 404 may include one or more layers. In the example depicted in FIG. 5, the pinned magnetic layer 404 sequentially includes a Co layer 520, a Co/Pt layer 522, an Ru layer 524, a Co layer 526, a Co/Pt layer 528, a Pt layer 530, a Ta layer 532, an Ru layer 534, a Ta layer 536 and a TaN layer 538. The Co layer 520 may have a thickness of about 0 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 5 Angstroms. The Ru layer 524 may have a thickness of about 3 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 4-5 or about 7-9 Angstroms. The Co layer 526 may have a thickness of about 0 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 5 Angstroms. The Pt layer 530, the Ta layer 532, the Ru layer 534, the Ta layer 536 and the TaN layer 538 each may have a thickness of about 0 to about 5 Angstroms, for example about 3 Angstroms.

The Co/Pt layer 522 may have a composition comprising [Co(x₁)/Pt(y₁)]_m, with x₁ having a thickness of Co of between about 1 to about 6 Angstroms, y₁ having a thickness of Pt of between about 1 Angstroms to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 1-8 Angstroms, and m having a number of between 0 and 5, where m represents the numbers of the Co/Pt layer 522 repeatedly formed in the film stack. For example, when x₁ is 5 Angstroms and y₁ is 3 Angstroms and m is number 2, it represents a film stack of Co layer (5 Angstroms)/Pt layer (3 Angstroms)/Co layer (5 Angstroms)/Pt layer (3 Angstroms).

The Co/Pt layer 528 may have a composition comprising [Co(x)/Pt(y)]_n, with x having a thickness of about 1 to about 6 Angstroms, y having a thickness of about 1 to about 10 Angstroms, for example about 1-8 Angstroms, and n having a number of between 3 and 10.

A capping layer 412 is then formed on the magnetic storage layer 410 in the film stack 402. In one embodiment, the capping layer 412 may include a magnetic layer. Suitable examples of the capping layer 412 include one or more layers of at one or more of CoFeB, MgO, Ta and Ru. In the example depicted in FIG. 5, the capping layer 412 includes a first layer 502 and a second layer 506 sandwiching an intermediate layer 504. The first layer 502 may have a

thickness of about 0 to about 5 nanometers (nm), for example about 2 nm. The first layer **502** may include one or more layers comprised of Ta and/or Ru. The second layer **506** may comprise MgO, and have a thickness of about 0 to about 15 Angstroms, for example 7 Angstroms. The intermediate layer **504** may include CoFeB. The intermediate layer **504** may have a thickness of about 0 to about 50 Angstroms, for example about 10 Angstroms. The intermediate layer **504** may have a composition of about 10 to about 30 percent B, and about 20 to about 60 percent Fe.

It is noted that the pinned magnetic layer **404**, the optional structure decoupling layer **405**, the tunneling barrier layer **408**, the magnetic storage layer **410**, the magnetic reference layer **406** and the capping layer **412** may be formed by any suitable techniques, such as CVD, PVD, ALD, spin-coating, spray coating, and any suitable manners. One example of systems that may be used to form these layers includes CENTURA®, PRECISION 5000® and PRODUCER® deposition systems, all available from Applied Materials Inc., Santa Clara, California. It is contemplated that other processing system, including those available from other manufacturers, may be adapted to practice the disclosure.

At operation **304**, a patterning process, e.g., an etching process, is performed to remove a portion **407** of the film stack **402** exposed and defined by an etching mask layer (not shown) from the substrate **301**, until the underlying substrate **400** is exposed, as shown in FIG. **4B**. The patterning process for patterning the film stack **402** may include several steps or different recipes configured to supply different gas mixtures or etchants to etch different layers in accordance with the materials included in each layer.

During patterning, an etching gas mixture or several gas mixtures with different etching species are sequentially supplied into the substrate surface to remove the portion of the film stack **402** from the substrate **400**.

The end point of the patterning process at operation **304** may be controlled by time or other suitable methods. For example, the patterning process may be terminated after performing for between about 200 seconds and about 10 minutes until the substrate **400** is exposed, as shown in FIG. **4B**. The patterning process may be terminated by determination from an endpoint detector, such as an OES detector or other suitable detector as needed.

At operation **306**, after the patterning process, a sidewall passivation layer **414** is formed on sidewalls **415** of the patterned film stack **402**, such as the sidewalls of the pinned magnetic layer **404**, the optional structure decoupling layer **405**, the tunneling barrier layer **408**, the magnetic storage layer **410**, the magnetic reference layer **406** and the capping layer **412**.

In one example, the sidewall passivation layer **414** may be a dielectric layer formed by a deposition process performed after the patterning process at operation **304**. For example, the sidewall passivation layer **414** may be formed by a CVD deposition, PVD deposition, ALD deposition, or other suitable deposition processes as needed. The sidewall passivation layer **414** may be formed from a nitrogen containing material, carbon containing material, or oxide containing material. Suitable exemplary materials for forming the sidewall passivation layer **414** includes SiN, SiCN, SiO₂, SiON, SiC, amorphous carbon, SiOC, aluminum oxide (Al₂O₃), aluminum nitride (AlN), and the like.

In another example, the sidewall passivation layer **414** may be formed from by-products generated during the patterning process at operation **304** accumulating on the sidewalls of the film stack **402** after the patterning process at operation **304**. For example, during patterning, a carbon

containing gas, an oxygen containing gas, or a nitrogen containing gas may be utilized in the etching gas mixture during the patterning process. The carbon elements, oxygen elements and the nitrogen elements from these gases may react with elements from the film stack **402**, forming side-products, residuals or build-ups adhering on the sidewalls **415** of the film stack **402**. Thus, in the example wherein the sidewall passivation layer **414** are formed from the patterning process from operation **304**, the gases supplied in the etching gas mixture at operation **304** may include at least one of carbon containing gas, oxygen containing gas, or nitrogen containing gas.

After the sidewall passivation layer **414** is formed on the sidewalls **415** of the film stack **402**, a further deposition process may be performed to form an insulation layer **416** on the portion **407** of the substrate **400** where the film stack **402** was removed during the patterning process at operation **304**, as shown in FIG. **4C**. The insulation layer **416** may be any suitable insulating materials that may later under series of etching and deposition processes to form interconnection structure (e.g., a backend process) in the insulation layer **416** to complete the device structure fabrication process. In one example, the insulation layer **416** is a silicon oxide layer or other suitable material.

At operation **308**, after the patterning process at operation **304** is completed and the sidewall passivation layer and the insulation layer **416** is formed on the substrate **400**, a thermal annealing process may be performed. The thermal annealing process is performed to repair, densify and enhance lattice structures of the film stack **402**, particularly the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** included in the film stack **402**. For example, after the thermal/annealing process, the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** may have stronger crystalline structures of (111), (220) and (311) plane peaks under XRD analysis prior to, e.g., without, the thermal/annealing process, thus enhancing crystallinity of the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** formed therein. During the annealing process, dopants from the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** are laterally driven away from the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406**, as shown by the arrow **420**, to the sidewall passivation layer **414**, as shown in FIG. **4D**. By forming a sidewall passivation layer **414** between the insulation layer **416** and the film stack **402**, the dopants from the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** may be efficiently retained laterally proximate to the sidewall passivation layer **414**, rather than vertically moving towards the capping layer **412**, the tunneling barrier layer **408** or the pinned magnetic layer **404** or the optional structure decoupling layer **405** formed in the film stack **402**. Lateral diffusion, rather than vertical diffusion, of the dopants may efficiently control the dopants from drifting to the sidewall passivation layer **414** so that the film properties and crystallinity of the layers in the film stack **402** will not be adversely impacted or altered. For example, in the embodiment wherein boron (B) dopants are included in the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406**, during the annealing process, boron dopants may be laterally diffused to the sidewall passivation layer **414**, forming boron compounds (such as boron oxide, boron nitride, or boron carbide, depending on the materials utilized to form the sidewall passivation layer **414**), which is a relatively stable compound that would not significantly alter electrical performance of the devices. Undesired dopant diffusion to the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** may result in with inaccurate magneti-

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zation or undesired atom spin directions when applying a magnetic field, thus adversely affecting the overall performance of the MTJ devices.

Thus, by utilizing the thermal annealing process performed after the patterning process and/or after the sidewall passivation and/or insulation layer deposition process, a more stable magnetization process and a better control of the dopant diffusion process may be obtained, as compared to the conventional practices having the annealing process performed right after each layer is formed in the film stack or right after the film stack **402** is formed on the substrate **400**.

In one example, the annealing process may be performed after the patterning process at operation **304** without or prior to forming the sidewall passivation layer **414** and the insulation layer **416**. In another example, the annealing process may be performed after the patterning process at operation **304** and the sidewall passivation and/or insulation layer deposition process at operation **306** as needed.

The thermal annealing process may be performed in a thermal annealing chamber, such as the processing chamber **200** depicted in FIG. 2. Alternatively, the annealing process may be performed in any processing chamber configured to provide enough thermal energy to the film stack **402** disposed on the substrate **400**. In one embodiment, the thermal annealing process may be performed in-situ process in the processing chamber wherein the patterning process at operation **304** or the deposition process at operation **306** was performed. The thermal annealing process may heat the substrate **400** to a temperature greater than 200 degrees Celsius, such as between about 250 degrees Celsius and about 550 degree Celsius, to assist dopants in the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** to diffuse outward and laterally from the film stack and enhance crystallinity of the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406**, and other layers in the film stack **402**.

During annealing, an annealing gas mixture may be supplied. Gases that may be supplied in the annealing gas mixture may include a nitrogen containing gas, such as NH_3 , N_2 , NF_3 , N_2O , NO_2 , NO and the like, an inert gas, such as Ar, He, Ne, Kr, Xe or the like, or an oxygen containing gas, such as O_2 , O_3 , N_2O , H_2O , CO_2 , CO and the like.

Alternatively, the annealing process may also be performed after the interconnection fabrication process (e.g., the back end fabrication process) is performed. It is noted that the interconnection fabrication process (e.g., the back end fabrication process) referred herein includes processes of patterning the insulation layer **416** to form trenches or vias in the insulation layer **416** and later having a conductive layer formed in trenches or vias defined in the insulation layer **416**. The temperature configured to perform the annealing process right after the deposition of the insulation layer **416** or sidewall passivation layer **414** deposition process at operation **306** and after the interconnection fabrication process (e.g., the back end fabrication process) may be the same or different. In one example, the temperature for the thermal annealing process configured to perform after the interconnection fabrication process (e.g., the back end fabrication process) may be slightly lower than the temperature of the thermal annealing process performed right after the deposition of the insulation layer **416** or sidewall passivation layer **414** deposition process at operation **306**.

After the thermal annealing process, the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** may be turned into a crystallized magnetic storage layer **422** and a crystallized magnetic reference layer **424**, as shown in FIG.

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4E, having crystal orientation mostly in one plane. The thermal energy provides during the thermal annealing process assists crystallizing the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** and other layers in the film stack **402** from amorphous state into crystalline state, thus efficiency enhancing magnetization of the film layers included in the film stack **402**. The thermal energy provided during the thermal annealing process at operation **308** assist growing the grains from the amorphous state into large sizes into crystallized grains, enhancing crystallinity of the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406**, and other layers in the film stack **402**. As desired crystallization of the magnetic storage layer **410** and the magnetic reference layer **406** is obtained, the overall electrical properties of the film stack **402** for manufacturing MTJ devices are improved.

Accordingly, processes and apparatus of forming MTJ device structures for MRAM are provided. The process advantageously provides a method to thermal anneal, e.g., thermal treat, a film stack utilized to form the MTJ devices. The thermal annealing process performed after the film stack deposition, patterning and sidewall passivation and insulation layer deposition process may efficiently crystallize the layers in the film stack in a manner (e.g., lateral diffusion rather than vertical diffusion) without damaging or impacting the film properties of the adjacent layers formed in the film stack. By doing so, the film stack utilized to form the MTJ structure may have a desired dopant profile and electrical performance and magnetization.

While the foregoing is directed to embodiments of the disclosure, other and further embodiments of the disclosure may be devised without departing from the basic scope thereof.

What is claimed is:

1. A method of forming a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate, comprising:

patterning a film stack having a tunneling barrier layer disposed between a magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer disposed on a substrate to remove a portion of the film stack from the substrate until an upper surface of the substrate is exposed, wherein the magnetic storage layer comprises a first magnetic storage sublayer, a second magnetic storage sublayer and a metallic intermediate layer therebetween;

forming a conformal sidewall passivation layer on sidewalls of the patterned film stack, wherein the sidewall passivation layer is in direct contact with a top surface of the substrate and covering the top surface, wherein the sidewall passivation layer has a vertical portion continuously coplanar along a vertical axis normal to a major axis of the substrate and a horizontal portion in direct contact with the substrate and extending outwardly from the vertical portion along the substrate;

forming an insulation layer comprising silicon oxide, where the portion of the film stack was removed during patterning, that is in direct contact with the sidewall passivation layer such that the horizontal portion is between the insulation layer and the substrate and the insulation layer does not contact the top surface of the substrate; and

subsequently performing a thermal annealing process to the film stack, wherein the insulation layer extends from a top surface of the sidewall passivation layer to the horizontal portion of the sidewall passivation layer wherein the film stack further comprises a pinning layer disposed between the substrate and the magnetic ref-

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reference layer, the pinning layer further comprising sequentially from the magnetic reference layer in the direction of the substrate; a Co layer, a Co/Pt layer, an Ru layer, a Co layer, a Co/Pt layer, a Pt layer, a Ta layer, an Ru layer, a Ta layer, and a TaN layer.

2. The method of claim 1, wherein performing the thermal annealing process further comprises:

maintaining the substrate temperature at between about 250 degrees Celsius and about 550 degree Celsius.

3. The method of claim 1, wherein the film stack further comprises a capping layer disposed on the magnetic storage layer.

4. The method of claim 1, wherein the film stack further comprises a pinning layer disposed between the substrate and the magnetic reference layer.

5. The method of claim 4, wherein the film stack further comprises a structure decoupling layer disposed between the pinning layer and the magnetic reference layer.

6. A method of forming a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate, comprising:

patterning a film stack having a tunneling barrier layer disposed between a magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer disposed on a substrate to remove a portion of the film stack from the substrate until an upper surface of the substrate is exposed, wherein the magnetic storage layer comprises a first magnetic storage sublayer, a second magnetic storage sublayer and a metallic intermediate layer therebetween;

forming a sidewall passivation layer comprising carbon containing materials or nitrogen containing materials on sidewalls of the patterned film stack, the sidewall passivation layer having a vertical portion coplanar along a vertical axis normal to a major axis of the substrate and a horizontal portion extending outwardly from the vertical portion along the substrate such that the horizontal portion covers the upper surface of the substrate where the portion of the film stack was removed during patterning; and

subsequently performing a thermal annealing process to the film stack

wherein the film stack further comprises a pinning layer disposed between the substrate and the magnetic reference layer, the pinning layer further comprising sequentially from the magnetic reference layer in the direction of the substrate; a Co layer, a Co/Pt layer, an Ru layer, a Co layer, a Co/Pt layer, a Pt layer, a Ta layer, an Ru layer, a Ta layer, and a TaN layer.

7. The method of claim 6, wherein performing the thermal annealing process further comprises:

maintaining the substrate temperature at between about 250 degrees Celsius and about 550 degree Celsius.

8. The method of claim 6, wherein the film stack further comprises a capping layer disposed on the magnetic storage layer.

9. The method of claim 6, wherein the film stack further comprises a pinning layer disposed between the substrate and the magnetic reference layer.

10. The method of claim 9, wherein the film stack further comprises a structure decoupling layer disposed between the pinning layer and the magnetic reference layer.

11. The method of claim 6, wherein the magnetic reference layer and the magnetic storage layer are fabricated from metal alloy with boron dopants.

12. The method of claim 6, wherein forming the sidewall passivation layer further comprises:

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forming a dielectric layer on the sidewalls of the patterned film stack by a chemical vapor deposition process.

13. The method of claim 12, wherein the dielectric layer of the sidewall passivation layer is at least one of SiN, SiCN, SiO₂, SION, SiC, amorphous carbon, amorphous carbon, SiOC, or aluminum nitride (AlN).

14. The method of claim 6, wherein the sidewall passivation layer is formed from by-products generated during the patterning of the film stack.

15. The method of claim 6, wherein forming the sidewall passivation layer further comprises:

forming an insulation layer on the substrate where the portion of the film stack is removed.

16. The method of claim 15, wherein the thermal annealing process is performed after a back end process is performed in the insulation layer or right after the insulation layer is formed on the substrate.

17. The method of claim 6, wherein performing the thermal annealing process further comprises:

altering crystalline structures of the magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer.

18. The method of claim 6, wherein performing the thermal annealing process further comprises:

driving dopants in the magnetic reference layer and the magnetic storage layer laterally outward to the sidewall passivation layer.

19. The method of claim 18, wherein the dopant reacts with the sidewall passivation layer to form a dopant compound.

20. A method of forming a magnetic tunnel junction structure on a substrate, comprising:

patterning a film stack having a tunneling barrier layer disposed between a magnetic reference layer and a magnetic storage layer disposed on a substrate to remove a portion of the film stack from the substrate until an upper surface of the substrate is exposed, wherein the magnetic storage layer comprises a first magnetic storage sublayer, a second magnetic storage sublayer and a metallic intermediate layer therebetween;

forming a sidewall passivation layer on sidewalls of the patterned film stack, the sidewall passivation layer having a vertical portion coplanar along a vertical axis normal to a major axis of the substrate and a horizontal portion extending outwardly from the vertical portion along the substrate such that the sidewall passivation layer covers the top surface of the substrate;

forming an insulation layer comprising silicon oxide, where the portion of the film stack was removed during patterning, that is in direct contact with the sidewall passivation layer on the substrate such that the horizontal portion is between the insulation layer and the substrate such that the insulation layer does not contact the top surface of the substrate; and

driving dopants from the magnetic reference layer and the magnetic storage layer laterally outward into the sidewall passivation layer by a thermal treatment process wherein the film stack further comprises a pinning layer disposed between the substrate and the magnetic reference layer, the pinning layer further comprising sequentially from the magnetic reference layer in the direction of the substrate; a Co layer a Co/Pt layer, an Ru layer, a Co layer, a Co/Pt layer, a Pt layer, a Ta layer, an Ru layer, a Ta layer, and a TaN layer.

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